



SUCCESS SKILL: COLLABORATION

BACKGROUND

This rubric is aligned to the [NCIES literature review](#) on collaboration. The value proposition is a clear research-based definition of collaboration as a success skill. This research-based rubric¹ is designed to provide useful, formative information that teachers can use to guide instruction and provide feedback to students and that they can use to reflect on the quality of their peer interactions. In this rubric, student performance is described along a continuum and balances content-specific and the more general nature of collaboration. Rubrics are provided by grade span, K-2, 3-5, and 6-12. The K-2 rubric includes both a teacher version and a version for primary students or early readers. The research-based definition of collaboration, identified in the literature review, embraces the concept of *collaboration as a process*:

“Students work in groups to improve their ability to work with others, and the quality of student interactions therefore should be the focus of teaching and learning. To be sure, intellectual gain and increased academic content knowledge and skill could be a bi- or co-product of collaborative activity, but this is not the focus either of instruction or of assessment related to collaboration. Rather, the focus is on the nature and quality of the collaborative activity and the interactions among group members” (Evans, 2020, p5).

BUILDING COLLABORATION SKILLS THROUGH CULTURALLY- RELEVANT GOLD STANDARD PBL

- **Use Gold Standard Project Based Teaching Practices to support students’ development of collaborative skills within a project.** Teachers can build a culture of collaboration by explicitly and implicitly promoting student interdependence and growth, open-ended inquiry, teamwork, and attention to quality. To manage activities, teachers work with students to organize tasks and schedules, set checkpoints and deadlines, find and use resources, and create products. Within the context of a project, teachers also intentionally scaffold [collaboration skills](#) through targeted instruction, tools, and practices that help students learn and practice strategies for working well together in teams. Throughout the project, teachers monitor and regulate student interactions to gather evidence of collaboration. [PBLWorks Strategy Guides](#) located on my.pblworks.org offer multiple resources to address instructional strategies that support collaboration.
- **Use research-based guidance to assess collaboration.** Throughout the project, teachers monitor and support student interactions to gather evidence of collaboration. To assess the quality of student interactions, Evans (2020) suggests that tasks need to:
 - **Be sufficiently complex.** Make the design rigorous and frame it with a challenging problem or meaningful question at the appropriate level of challenge. The design should be challenging enough to elicit group discussion, negotiation, and collective efforts.
 - **Be open-ended.** Tasks that are open-ended require students to determine what is relevant, plan how they will demonstrate their knowledge, and offer multiple pathways for solutions. Open-ended tasks “allow for multiple, defensible solutions and, further, require students to apply (or transfer) their learning to novel situations” (p. 18).
 - **Be authentic.** Using the Gold Standard Design Element, Authenticity, in project design provides students with opportunities to engage with real-world contexts, tasks, tools, or impact. The PBLWorks Blog, [What Does it Take for a Project to be “Authentic”?](#) is a helpful resource for planning.
 - **Be reflective of culture and context.** [PBL supports culturally responsive teaching practices](#), and it is important to note that while assessing the quality of student interactions cultural differences must be considered. Some differences are verbal, what is considered appropriate communication and sharing of resources, ideas, or efforts; other differences are non-verbal and mediate what is considered appropriate body language, conflict resolution, and task management tactics. Verbal and non-verbal interactions may vary across cultural contexts.
 - **Make student thinking visible.** Offer students opportunities to make their thinking visible to their group. Use [Structured reflections](#) to do this.

¹ These rubrics were created by National Center for Improvement of Educational Assessment (Center for Assessment) in collaboration with PBLWorks. This version of the rubric integrates asset-based language based on the *Ready for Rigor: A Framework for Culturally Responsive Teaching* (Hammond, 2013).



Collaboration: Grade 6-12

Collaboration occurs when students work together to complete a project and must combine thinking, skills, and efforts to do so.

DIMENSION	Quality of Collaboration			
	<i>Select the column where most of the criteria that describe what a student knows and can do independently.</i>			
	BEGINNING	EMERGING	DEVELOPING	DEMONSTRATING
Planning and Group Decision-Making	- Identifies one way to “best” manage and complete the work. - Agrees to complete their role or task the group assigned and does it their own way. - Displays inflexibility that sometimes causes conflict in the group.	- Restates some ways the group discussed how best to manage and complete the work. - Volunteers a way that they could help the group. - Withdraws from the discussion when the group disagrees.	- Adds ideas about how best to manage and complete the work. - Suggests roles or tasks for the group that are equitable. - Identifies the main areas of disagreement in the group to help focus the conversation.	- Suggests ways that the group could manage and complete the work, noting tradeoffs with different approaches. - Suggests roles or tasks based on the unique knowledge, abilities, or interests of those in the group. - Suggests ways the group can make decisions when there is a disagreement.
Communicating About Thinking	Restates the thinking of others.	Asks questions of the group to better understand their thinking.	Identifies when the thinking of the group does not make sense or is lacking in some way.	- Rephrases the thinking of the group and connects ideas to move the group forward. - Asks for other perspectives and input from group members.
Contributing Resources, Ideas, and Efforts	- Focuses on what they are asked to do. - Completes their part of the group project on time. - Lets group members figure out what they need on their own.	- Identifies the ideas and resources they need to complete the work. - Asks the group what help they need or resources they have. - Shares their work and looks at others’ work at the end of the project.	- Brainstorms ideas with the group. - Finds resources for others, when asked. - Asks the group to consider ways to improve the project’s quality. - Asks group members if they need any input or feedback.	- Contributes important ideas that move the group forward. - Provides resources to support the group. - Suggests ways to improve the project’s quality. - Helps others and gives feedback throughout the project.
Monitoring Processes	Focuses on getting their part of the group project done.	Identifies how their work shows quality.	Monitors the group’s project quality and process throughout the project.	- Suggests ways to adjust the group’s process to benefit the project quality. - Adjusts their efforts to benefit the group.